

DBT Behavioral Chain Analysis

Dialectical Behavior Therapy · Problem Behavior Assessment Form

Purpose

The chain analysis is a cornerstone DBT assessment tool. It maps the full sequence of vulnerabilities, precipitating events, thoughts, emotions, and actions that led to a problem behavior — and identifies where skills could have interrupted the chain. Complete collaboratively and non-judgmentally.

Client: _____ Date: _____ Session #: _____ Therapist: _____

Step 1: Define the Problem Behavior

Describe the problem behavior in specific, observable, behavioral terms. Avoid vague labels like 'self-harm' — be specific: what exactly happened, when, where, how.

Describe the specific problem behavior:

Step 2: What Made You Vulnerable? (PLEASE Check)

Identify vulnerabilities that lowered your resilience before the chain began. Check all that apply: [] Poor sleep [] Illness / pain [] Skipped meals [] Alcohol / substances [] Skipped medication [] Avoided exercise [] Intense emotional event in past 24 hrs [] Other: _____

Describe the vulnerability state in more detail:

Step 3: The Prompting Event

What specific event started the chain? The prompting event is the trigger that set the chain in motion. It may seem minor — that is normal and expected.

Describe the prompting event (who, what, where, when):

Step 4: Links in the Chain

List each link — thought, feeling, sensation, action — in order, from the prompting event to the problem behavior. Include the emotion intensity (0-10) at each link.

Chain links (use as many rows as needed):

#	Link (Thought / Feeling / Action / Sensation)	Intensity (0-10)	Skill Opportunity?
1			Y / N
2			Y / N
3			Y / N
4			Y / N
5			Y / N
6			Y / N
7			Y / N
8			Y / N

Step 5: Consequences

What happened IMMEDIATELY after the problem behavior (within minutes/hours)? Short-term consequences often reinforce the behavior even when long-term consequences are harmful.

Immediate consequences (positive and negative):

Step 6: Where Could a Skill Have Helped?

Go back through the chain and mark 2-3 points where a DBT skill could have interrupted it. Be specific about which skill and how it would have changed the next link.

Skill intervention points:

Clinician Reminder

Clinician Note: The chain analysis is not a punishment or a confrontation — it is a collaborative problem-solving tool. Validate each link before moving to the next. Clients often feel shame reviewing problem behaviors; keep the tone curious and compassionate. The goal is understanding, not judgment.